death in New York. Grief turned B.B. Pradhan into a rebel, but Mohan Singh is an ordinary man dealing with buried hurt in a conventional way. However, Mohan Singh lent another dimension to my craft." Kher elaborates: "Having been in films for 41 years, I can make characters come easily to me. Competency is the greatest villain of brilliance, but I don't let it overpower the craft. I want to make the process difficult to add nuanced layers. That's what I did for Mohan Singh."

Brilliance is tangible through the film's one-hour-47-minute runtime, and it expectedly won the Best Feature, Best Director and Best Actor awards during its Canadian Premiere at the IFFSA Toronto Festival.

Kher believes that not every film is made for box office success, and films like *Calorie* should make the rounds of film festivals. "Film festivals are absolutely essential for filmmakers. Directors, writers, producers, actors from across the world gather at these festivals, and it is important that these human stories get noticed," Kher adds.

The evening was getting dark, and Kher was still bathed in the haze of the yellow lamp, speaking gently about *Calorie*, the perils of existence and the exhilaration of films. He acknowledges that grief cannot be erased, but no matter how enormous the 'emotional weight' of loss, life rejigs itself and grief is no longer an ill-fated companion but an obligatory configuration. ■

—Preeti Verma Lal



CINEMA ▼

DARK IS BEAUTIFUL

MADHURI DIXIT-NENE PUSHES HER ACTING BOUNDARIES WITH A SERIAL-KILLER TURN IN HOTSTAR SPECIAL *MRS DESHPANDE*

Cast Madhuri Dixit-Nene in anything and you hope to see that pearly, perfect smile that's melted many a heart. Only, in the latest JioHotstar series, *Mrs Deshpande*, Dixit plays a serial killer, and there's minimal deployment of that much-vaunted smile; when it does emerge, its motive is under scrutiny. For filmmaker Nagesh Kukunoor, it was pertinent that the actress didn't "fall back on stuff she's used in the past" as he went about creating an "iconic, likeable villainess for the ages and to root for".

In fact, a common cue Kukunoor gave to Dixit to get the desired result was—"I want less MD, more *Mrs D*." "I wanted her to be this person who moves slowly and deliberately; there's complete economy to her movement," adds Kukunoor. On Madhuri's part, she enjoyed both the "friendly banter" with Kukunoor and playing a complex character like Sakshi Deshpande, which fulfilled what she has loved doing for nearly four decades: "play strong women that have something to say and stand by". "I understood the strength of the character; it's in her silences," she notes, "it's what she doesn't say more than what she says".

MRS DESHPANDE CONTINUES MADHURI'S REPERTOIRE OF ESSAYING RESILIENT WOMEN SURVIVING AGAINST ODDS

***Mrs Deshpande* marks Kukunoor's second show and also his second adaptation of the year, after the acclaimed *The Hunt* (SonyLIV). While the latter's inspiration was a book, this time around it's a French show, *La Mante*, which in turn was recently adapted into a Korean drama, *Queen Mantis* (on Netflix). Kukunoor, though, says he's given the crime thriller a nifty spin rather than a remake. "It's a full tonal shift," he says. "The French show is brooding, dark, extremely self-conscious and serious. This is a twisty thriller, a character-driven drama as opposed to a police procedural of which there are too many out there."**

***Mrs Deshpande* continues Madhuri's repertoire of essaying resilient women surviving against odds as seen in films like *Lajja*, *Mrityudand* or even *Beta*. Selective with her work on streaming, having only done the series, *The Fame Game*, and the feature *Maja Maa*, the show's premise, she says, is demonstrative of how OTT can be more liberating for writers and filmmakers. "To make something like *Mrs Deshpande*, it'd be difficult to do it as a movie for cinemas," she adds. Only on streaming can one of our most beloved actresses play a killer heroine and be accepted. ■**

—Suhani Singh